

Going Niche

Now that you know how to deal with the biggies of the social networking world, here's something for adding more flair to your efforts. For setting up a well rounded internet personality, you should dabble in some of the more niche social networking platforms that have come up. Most of these niche platforms are driven by some common interest, goal, or objective. In most cases they integrate into your bigger social networking platforms like Twitter and Facebook. Some of the most prominent ones are listed below along with our recommendations on how to use them.

Knowledge

Quora.com – Social networking is fun, but there are times when you do want to showcase your other side. Your intelligent, knowledgeable side can be put to good use by answering questions on this knowledge sharing web site which has a strong social backbone. *[Check out our Web Watch section (Pg 24) for more info]*

Geeky

Wakoopa.com – This network is meant for us geeks. It's a social network that tracks software and games that members use. Based on what it analyses, it gives you recommendations and helps you discover loads of new software. On the social networking side it lets you share

reviews and have discussions with other software enthusiasts. The more software you install and use the more points you get. Points help you level-up from Newbie to Devotee to all the way up to Overlord. It's all quite fun – like an MMORPG.

Creative expression

Tumblr.com and **Posterous.com** – These services according to some people lie somewhere between Twitter and Facebook. Simply put, they are blogging sites which allow you to post richer content compared to the 140 character plain text offered by Twitter. And the content which includes images, quotes, video, links, etc., can be put up in an easy manner. Tumblr allows you to follow people and be followed, while your dashboard shows the live stream of posts.

Music

Last.fm and **blip.fm** – These are platforms for you to showcase your taste in music, and at the same time, let you connect with people of similar musical leanings. Last.fm works by first analysing your taste through scrobbling – a process in which information about whatever you play on your local machine gets sent to its servers. This gives you a play-count, which is good for bragging value too. Next it suggests neighbours or people with similar musical tastes. Great for finding your musical soulmates from around the world.

Goal based

43things.com – This web site is a focus group of sorts, where people who want to set

couch to the occasional fellow traveller, you still get to learn a lot. Also check out IndiMike.com for satisfying further wanderlust.

Be accessible

Gone are the days of internet anonymity. Not having a web presence these days is like burying your head in the sand. You should ideally be doing the opposite and make yourself easily accessible and unify your online presence. There are many tools that help you achieve this integration. Splash pages for instance get all your various avatars under one roof. www.about.me and www.flavours.me are good tools that allow you to set up a home page of sorts that points visitors to all of your online content on various platforms – both niche and mainstream. The beauty of these pages in the simplicity, and creativity you can unleash in a few simple steps. Also, you can choose to make one profile your hub or base – usually a blog, Facebook (with privacy sorted) or even Twitter, and share this splash-page link on all other communities.

Another useful class of tools is meant to streamline your updating. Services such as hootsuite.com and ping.fm allow you to post from one place to many of your social networking accounts. These services even let you schedule your posts. This is done so that your posts make the maximum impact, and reach the largest audience available. People are known to be most active on social networks at certain times such as between 5 PM to 8 PM for instance. In this case you would want your posts to be pushed to your network in

Lost and found

When Himani Sanghvi lost her wallet recently, the person who found it happened to get in touch with one of her 2,155 followers, who in turn instantly remembered her Twitter handle and tweeted to her about it.



"The wallet had all my debit cards, membership cards and even my PAN card. If it weren't for the top-of-mind recall created by my social networking presence, I probably wouldn't have got it back.

"I got my internship at Hindustan Times during my college days because of twitter. My future colleague was following a friend of mine and me. We got talking, and then the next day he asked us to come to his office. We were introduced to our boss right then and got the internship. Even right now where I'm teaching, the job I got was through a Twitter friend."



similar goals come together and help each other achieve them. People share inspirational stories and so can you, as you inch your way towards achieving those goals.

Travel

Couchsurfing.com - If you're serious about travel, this is a community you must check out. It's a volunteer-based worldwide network connecting travellers with members of local communities, who offer free accommodation and/or advice. Even if you can't offer your

that optimal window. Hootsuite also gives you intelligent analytics and a historical reporting archive of link click-through statistics from your social updates.

There are still more integration tools available that will let you post specialised content from various other social networks into Twitter and Facebook. Take twitterfeed.com for instance – you can use it to tweet songs you are currently listening to. Since automated posts are something people don't take too kindly to – it's akin to spamming